

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | MONDAY, JUNE 22, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Abandoned oil, gas wells burden state

In Illinois, getting operators to pay for plugging dormant wells can take decades, costing taxpayers

By **Adriana Pérez**
and **Jonathan Bullington**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

CHRISTIAN COUNTY, Ill. — By James Myers’ estimate, it’s been at least 10 years since the four oil wells on his farmland were abandoned.

That’s 10 years of farming around idle pump jacks and tabulating acres damaged by fluid leaks. Ten years of finding dead animals — birds and, once, a deer — in the open concrete pit the company dug out near its oil storage tanks to hold the salt water it once extracted from below ground.

Ten years of waiting for the company, or the state, to restore his land.

“I’m still waiting,” the 87-year-old said on a Thursday in May, sitting in his truck feet from those storage tanks — now rusted and tagged with graffiti — and that pit, filled with rainwater from a recent storm. “I’ll be dead before it ever happens.”

The wells on Myers’ property are among nearly 200 in central and southern Illinois once operated by Duncan Oil Co., which has been locked in a two-decades-long court case with the state over its repeated failures to plug leaking or unproductive wells.

The Illinois Department of Natural Resources and the Illinois attorney general’s office sued Duncan Oil Co., and the subsequent settlement agreement halted the attempted

transfer of those wells from Duncan to Dix Oil Co. Both share the same mailing address in downstate Salem and are led by the same family.

The department touts the still-active case as an example of how it prevented abandoned oil wells from becoming the state’s responsibility to plug.

“Because we were able to catch (the attempted transfer) in time, we negotiated the plugging of most of the wells,” said Dan Brennan, IDNR’s oil and gas director, in an interview earlier this year.

Indeed, most of Duncan’s wells were either plugged or brought back into production under Dix Oil’s operation. But 22 years later, the Tribune has found, 15 of their wells are abandoned and unplugged. Ten of them are, as of this month, on a



James Myers, pictured near his farm in Assumption in Christian County, Ill., was a teenager in the 1950s when the oil wells on his family’s land were drilled thousands of feet through layers of sand, lime and shale.
E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

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Kelly Kennard, right, a volunteer with Friends of Kenwood Academy, jokes with co-workers while setting up their booth before the start of eighth grade graduation at the school on June 1 in Chicago. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Schools learn to hustle as district funding lags

Amid Chicago’s budget crunch, campuses must lean on dollars they raise independently — through facility rentals, parent-run fundraisers and more

By **Mila Koumpilova**
CHALKBEAT
and **Kate Armanini**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Karen Calloway is always hunting for more ways to bring in dollars for Kenwood Academy.

In recent years, the principal has rented out the South Side high school’s campus to churches, nonprofits and sports leagues, and leaned on a new parent group to drum up donations. The effort to supplement what the school receives directly from Chicago Public Schools has paid off.

Kenwood spent \$418,983 in outside money in fiscal year 2025,

compared with a low of about \$90,000 in 2021, according to an analysis by Chalkbeat and the Tribune.

At Kenwood, a predominantly Black high school where about half of the students are low-income, that funding has paid for athletic equipment and uniforms, student clubs and college tours.

“Regardless of the budget, as a principal, you should want to create other arms of revenue for your school,” Calloway said. “It’s being flexible and being nimble about how you use the funding that you have.”

Private fundraising has long been seen as a way to pad school budgets in wealthier communities, usually to pay for nice-to-haves, such as field trips and student clubs. But as the district

grapples with growing financial woes, more Chicago schools have leaned on parent fundraising, rental income, cell tower revenue and more to pay for essentials, including staffing.

In fiscal year 2025, district-run campuses spent a total of \$48 million in independently raised revenue, the Chalkbeat and Chicago Tribune analysis found. That’s up 78% since 2021, when the district was newly flush with federal pandemic relief.

In an email, a district spokesperson said the total spent in fiscal year 2025 was \$51.8 million, but could not explain the discrepancy.

North Side schools have remained dominant in bringing in this outside funding, but some higher-poverty South and West Side campuses such as Kenwood

increasingly held their own. Across the city, principals say they appreciate the boost, even as they note playing landlord and overseeing fundraisers can siphon time away from efforts to improve instruction.

The district made some cuts to school budgets this spring to chip at a \$732.5 million deficit, under pressure from billions in long-term debt and pension liabilities, aging infrastructure and state funding that remains short of what Illinois deems “adequate.”

“The district’s budget is getting close to the breaking point, so principals are hustling around for additional revenue, the district’s hustling around to buy additional savings and the long-term revenue

See **SCHOOLS** on Page A2

No end in sight for US border mission

Military confronting Mexico drug cartels, smugglers at a cost

By **Eric Schmitt**
THE NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — For more than a year, the Pentagon has deployed about 9,000 active-duty troops along nearly 2,000 miles of the southwest border to confront migrants, smugglers and drug cartels.

The troops are still there — at a cost of tens of millions of dollars each week — even though the Trump administration months ago largely achieved its goal of slashing illegal crossings.

The military patrols, working closely with Customs and Border Protection as well as the Mexican military, have pushed Mexican cartels and smugglers into more remote mountainous areas to evade detection.

But threats to U.S. troops are rising, U.S. officials say.

Some members of Congress have questioned whether the patrols are the best use of active-duty troops who would otherwise be training for deployments to Eastern Europe, the Middle East or the Indo-Pacific. Lawmakers and independent analysts have voiced concerns that the border missions will distract from training, drain resources and undermine readiness.

The mission marked a milestone late last month when its third commander, Maj. Gen. Curtis D. Taylor of the Army’s 1st Armored Division, took control of one of the centerpieces of the Trump administration’s Western Hemisphere security policy.

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U.S. soldiers patrol near a southern border wall in Douglas, Arizona.
ADRIANA ZEHBRAUSKAS/ THE NEW YORK TIMES 2025

CHICAGOLAND

Too many tornadoes

Illinois has had at least 147 tornadoes so far this year — the most of any year on record. Experts say this pace is not normal: Illinois experienced an average of 54 tornadoes annually between 1990 and 2020. **Page A3**

NATION & WORLD

Trump threatens Iran

High-level U.S.-Iran talks on their interim deal to end the war had a tense start as Tehran took offense at comments by President Donald Trump, who threatened to attack. **Page B1**

ARTS & LIVING

Rosalía thrills, reinvents

At a sold-out United Center, the multilingual vocalist reimagined the arena concert to phenomenal effect, blending elements of opera, ballet, interpretive dance, magic, cabaret, theater and comedy. **Page B5**

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